

Environmental impact of AI

Posted by u/Demonickiller63 • • 0 points • 24 comments

Bit of a brain-splash right now, however, i have genuine DISGUST about the use of ai. Without doxxing myself im an environmental scientist of sorts and AI use genuinely makes me nauseous.

Even if i forgive (i dont) the blatant stealing of artists' work, the psychosis, the soullessness, the pure pervasive nature of AI and it being everywhere, i simply cannot push past the disgusting effect AI has on the environment.

Forests and wilderness destroyed for mining of the rare elements used in the chips, pollution from mining. Land bulldozed for the datacentres, water tables being decimated for cooling. Heat produced by the processing. It makes me feel like im going INSANE.

The complete disregard by the evil-corporate-conglomerate-billionaire AI "leaders" when it comes to the one and only planet we live on fills me with absolute fucking despair.

Comments

u/the-magician-misphet • 2 points • 2025-12-19 17:56 UTC

What gets me is they swear up and down that water cooled systems are closed systems... even if they are you're telling me that every single ounce of water is not disappearing to some form of evaporation somewhere? I'm pressing x to doubt hard.

u/QuantityExcellent338 • 1 points • 2025-12-19 01:33 UTC

AI is an interesting technology that, I think if we use it correctly and responsibly, is actually a productivity boost for many, in my opinion mainly aiding in coding. But the fact that behind the scenes its just a machine that doesnt understand, reason or have tastes and just predicts whats next, its easy to get lulled into a false sense of security when even as 'smart' it has gotten, they still regularly hallucinate and you need to doublecheck everything it outputs. But if you do that, it can save time.

But for me to comfortably view it as 'just a technology', the real tangible issues that need to be solved is the environmental impact and data scraping. The projected power needs the data centers need are not sustainable, and the data is often just stolen willy nilly and these AI companies will just avoid any accountability until the either bubble bursts or people just stop caring

If we have more companies like the developers for Cascadeur, a machinelearned 3D animation software whose dataset they have recorded on their own, so ethically I'm on board. And I'm not kidding but I'd forgive AI for everything if it makes politicians lobby for nuclear power instead of burning coal, I'd embrace it if it actually makes that happen.

u/Remarkable-Title-387 • 1 points • 2025-12-17 18:10 UTC

Okay so what about the fact that we are building all these houses in America that no one can afford? I have seen more deer in the last year alone than I have in my entire life and I live in the deep south. I hope you care about this one too.

If you live in the US then you are forced to drive a gas powered car to work because EV's are pretty much a luxury(scam).

Any factory takes up more space and could possibly even poison your river if the owners don't give a shit.

AI is a literal cherry on top of the bullshit we have already been dealing with and preaching about but none of the other problems have been solved so what is the point here?

u/Raudys • 1 points • 2025-12-17 11:32 UTC

How about we focus on real solutions like promoting nuclear power instead of blaming the consumers.

u/thekbob • 2 points • 2025-12-17 13:56 UTC

Reduce demand instead of increasing/replacing supply is actively necessary to meet any non-catastrophic climate goals.

So adding in a brand new power hungry technology that's providing a net negative value is literally the opposite of what we should be doing.

That's not a consumer thing; last I checked, most folks don't want AI added to search, Windows, Android, iOS, etc., but are being forced into it. If anything, being pro AI is anti consumer because it's becoming not a choice.

u/Raudys • 0 points • 2025-12-17 14:12 UTC

AI only uses ~ 0.3% of global energy. Source IEA. Reducing demand is NOT actively necessary, in fact, it's a distraction.

u/ducklady92 • 1 points • 2025-12-17 11:49 UTC

How about we do both? I didn't realize you had to pick.

The consumer should be able to make informed decisions about the products they use. Many aren't aware about the environmental impact, or at least not to the full extent, because it's being intentionally downplayed by those who stand to profit. And if they do know and still use it frivolously, they SHOULD be made to feel bad.

u/Raudys • 1 points • 2025-12-17 13:25 UTC

How about no? Focusing on "both solutions" when one's environmental impact is entirely dependant on how bad the other is makes 0 sense. It's the same as if you have cancer and focus 50% of your money and time on chemotherapy and 50% on optimizing your vitamins intake. One of these is thousands of times more important

than the other. "Focus on both" is bad advice. That's why oil companies love folk like you who "bring awareness" to things that are really just distractions.

u/ducklady92 • 1 points • 2025-12-17 15:38 UTC

That's a bad analogy and you know it, but if you'd like to use it: where is the HARM in dedicating 95% of my energy on chemotherapy and 5% on optimizing my vitamins intake? Surely getting healthy is a net positive when your body is ravaged by illness, no?

Obviously we as ordinary citizens have much more power over one option than the other. You can do two things without focusing 50/50 energy on them. Surely you're aware of that. Are you insinuating that AI should be classed a non-issue? That if nuclear power efforts are proven fruitful, that makes the rest of this argument null and void? Crazy that you can read the litany of ways in which AI is a drain on the environment and say "well if we had nuclear power it wouldn't be a problem"

u/Demonickiller63 • 2 points • 2025-12-17 11:35 UTC

I support the real solutions. I am all for nuclear power, i am all for renewables, wilderness restoration, freedom for all. But we fundamentally won't get a better world if we just allow capitlists and their products (ai in this case, and the demonstrably disgusting effects on the environment) to roam free. I blame the billionaires and corporate rats 1000x more than the consumer, but that doesn't reduce the impact of the individual at all.

u/anti--imperialist • 2 points • 2025-12-17 14:03 UTC

Exactly, we also don't know how many of those pro ai accounts are bot accounts, in the real world where I live ppl I talk to, there skepticism about ai and how it already affected the hiring process and reducing jobs that are available. Not seeing gung ho pro ai mentality irl, quite the opposite actually

u/LordPenvelton • 4 points • 2025-12-17 11:22 UTC

The worst part, for me, is that many of the ones promoting it (both those on top, and the fanboys), believe they are creating some sort of mechanical god that will fix everything for everyone.

Like we didn't already know how to solve climate change... it's just that the big companies chose to make it worse instead, because it makes the line go up.

u/thelaughingman_1991 • 4 points • 2025-12-17 11:31 UTC

I'm a little ignorant of AI on a broader scale, but still feel it's only "solved" problems that aren't really there. I've heard it's being utilised for things like cancer detection, but is attacking human creativity at a time when it's arguably never been needed more.

Show me AI being used to regulate ocean temperatures. Show me AI working towards aiding humanitarian efforts. Show me AI reversing the terrifying acceleration of climate change.

The planet is cooking and we've just created a more effective fuel for the fire.

u/Elegant-Pie6486 • 1 points • 2025-12-17 18:53 UTC

>Show me AI reversing the terrifying acceleration of climate change.

It's being used on nuclear fusion and battery technology which would massively help

climate change. There's also work in material science which may (still early days) reducing energy demand by orders of magnitude more than all of AI is using.

u/astrocoffee7 • 3 points • 2025-12-17 13:29 UTC

Recently there was a paper where a group of scientists (that weren't funded by corporations, unless they lied in the conflict of interests section) calculated that AI usage can offset environmental and social impact by finding solutions to these problems. I can't find the paper, if somebody has it please link it!

It was...delusional. It assumed corporations will actually use AI like this. That public will be properly educated. It was as if I were reading a utopian sci-fi story. "And then we all joined hands and sang in joy!"

As someone working in academia, I worry about this sentiment in scientific spaces, this idealism bordering on manic positivity, that AI will successfully be used for the things you described. Can it be used for this? Yeah. Will it be used for this? Not in the capitalist hellscape that is our society.

u/Demonickiller63 • 3 points • 2025-12-17 11:38 UTC

Exactly. If Large language models were being used as pattern recognition software to help with dense data like you said, in medicine, logistics? Sure, i can understand how there are uses for AI in those fields (of course with human supervision)

But what it has currently been used for? Useless. Genuinely just a soulless rot on the planet.

u/yayspurs • 2 points • 2025-12-17 11:50 UTC

Don't get too grumpy or we'll turn the AI grumpy when it eventually steals these comments to be fed back to someone.

u/Demonickiller63 • 4 points • 2025-12-17 11:51 UTC

Maybe if my text is sufficiently rage-filled the servers will short circuit and I'll destroy an ai datacentre! We can only hope.

u/yayspurs • 2 points • 2025-12-17 14:32 UTC

Oor wee aal sturt splellin werdZ in
whays thut breyk thu
perdictshuns und eets ull jibrish

u/Demonickiller63 • 2 points • 2025-12-17 11:26 UTC

Bang on. Im no finance guy or anything, but as far as i am aware, the AI industry right now is a money blackhole. I genuinely can't think of a reason why it's being funded outside of "we know climate collapse and associated problems will cause untold societal unrest so AI surveillance and weaponry will keep the plebians in line"

Like we KNOW what we need to do to fix the climate, but instead of that, the evil "elites" and technocrats decide to just go "eh, idgaf" and make it worse because as you said, line go up.